

LAND OF EXTREMES

Asia

Asia is the world's largest continent, covering around 30 percent of the Earth's land area. It extends nearly 4,000 miles (6,500 km) from the polar regions in the north of Siberian Russia, through the subtropics and tropics to the islands of Southeast Asia, which lie on and below the equator. Due to its vast size, parts of Central Asia experience a continental climate with extremes of heat in the summer and cold in the winter.

To the south of the Siberian plateau lies a sparsely populated landscape of mountain and plateau, desert, and steppe. The southern parts of Asia are geologically much younger. Tectonic activity to the east and southeast has created numerous volcanic island arcs that form the western side of the Pacific Ring of Fire. The Himalayas isolate the Indian subcontinent from the rest of Asia, and have a profound effect on the climate of Asia as a whole. More than 100 mountains have summits higher than 23,600 ft (7,200 m), and little moisture is left in the air flowing over them into Central Asia during the summer.

SIBERIAN TUNDRA



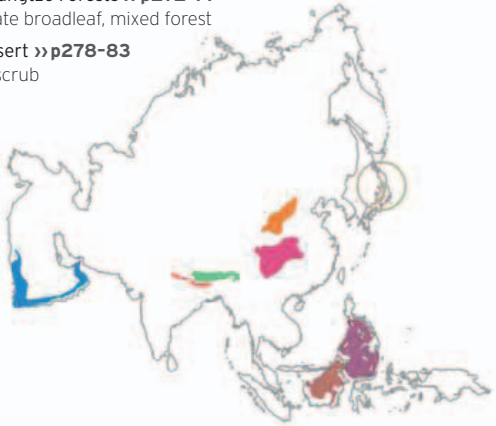
Running along the coast of northeastern Russia, this subarctic tundra is a breeding ground for migratory birds and a temporary home to herds of reindeer.



Red Sea

FEATURED ECOREGIONS

- | | |
|--|---|
|  Arabian Highlands »p248-53
Montane woodland, desert scrub |  Nihonkai Montane Forest »p284-91
Temperate broadleaf, mixed forest |
|  Terai-Duar Savanna »p254-65
Subtropical grassland |  Bornean Rainforest »p292-301
Tropical, subtropical moist broadleaf forest |
|  Eastern Himalayas »p266-71
Temperate broadleaf, mixed forest |  Sulu-Sulawesi Seas »p302-09
Marine, coral reefs |
|  Upper Yangtze Forests »p272-77
Temperate broadleaf, mixed forest | |
|  Gobi Desert »p278-83
Desert, scrub | |



ARABIAN PENINSULA

Much of this peninsula is desert, but mountain ranges around the margins have woodlands with plants and birds found nowhere else.

MONSOON CLIMATE



India and Southeast Asia have a monsoon climate. In summer, the land is warmer than the sea. Rising warm air creates low pressure systems that draw in cool moist air from the oceans, resulting in torrential rainfall. In winter, the sea is warmer than the land and so the air flow reverses, causing the dry season.

INDIAN OCEAN

